Grace Truong

Government 2306

Dr. Jared Alan Stewart

September 2, 2025

Government Meeting Attendance

This week, I attended the 6:30 pm September 2, 2025, city council meeting at Arlington's city hall on West Abram St, 76010 and it was truly a sad day in the city of Arlington. The three topics on the agenda were the "Construction Chapter Amendment: Adoption of Green Building Performance Standards for Multi-family and Mixed-use Developments", "Amendment to Code of Ordinances, Administration Chapter, Section 3.09 - Unity Council", and the "Suspension of the Anti-Discrimination Chapter".

The first topic discussed was the Construction Chapter Amendment. This topic went a lot quicker than the other two, as there was only one public speaker and everyone on the council voted to pass it. What was this amendment to construction about? The change would require new residential and mixed-use buildings to meet environmental and sustainability standards for energy efficiency and water conservation. This ordinance is an official law change, modifying Article 1, section 1.04 of the building code, adding a new subsection H. Anyone violating these new rules could result in $2,000 fines for each violation. Connecting this action to federalism, Arlington is a local government that is making a new law independently while working under the state and federal authorities.

The second topic we will touch on is the “Amendment to Code of Ordinances, Administration Chapter, Section 3.09 - Unity Council”. This amendment for the Unity Council is to add “build unity” (inclusion) and “champion great neighborhoods” (strong, safe neighborhoods). Making sure the work of the Unity Council aligns with the city’s priorities. One public speaker stood out the most, DeeJay Johannessan, who is the CEO at HELP Center for LGBT Health and Wellness. He asked that everyone be supported and “please don’t change anything” because if it’s not broken, don’t try to fix it, “things have been perfect so far”. Texas law allows cities to create boards like the Unity Council to handle specific issues like bringing people together to support diverse communities, including people with disabilities, LGBTQ, veterans, seniors, and more. The goal is to eliminate racism and discrimination and promote equity and equality. Representation and democracy at a local level reflect the broader principle in the Texas government that citizens have input, not just at the state capitol but also in city halls through councils, boards, and commissions.

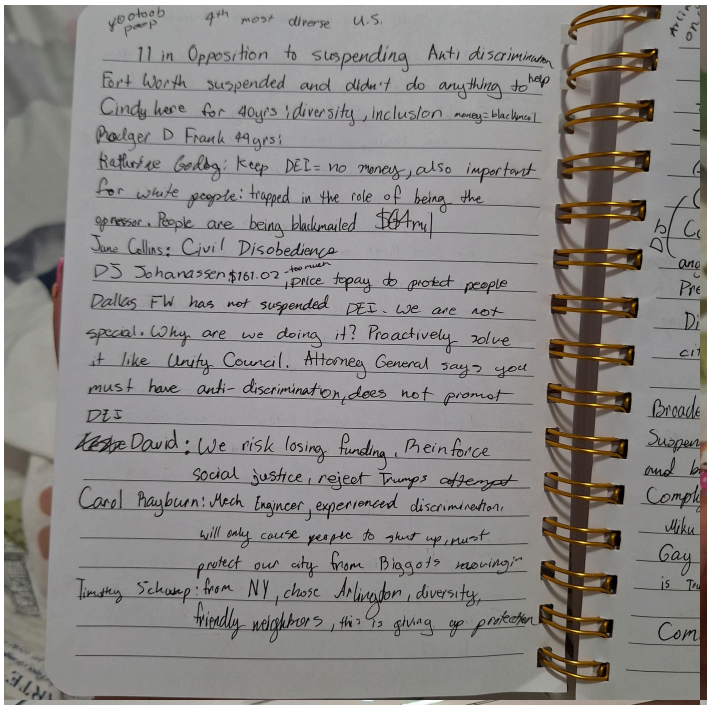
The third topic that was discussed was the “Suspension of the Anti-Discrimination Chapter”. By far, this was the longest and most controversial topic that was brought up, having twelve speakers from the public in total, only one of whom supported the measure. Mayor Jim Ross stated that the city has already lost a federal grant due to having the word “inclusion” in its priorities. To gain the second $65 million grant, we must suspend the city’s Anti-discrimination chapter of its code. In connection to federalism, we are being blackmailed out of $65,000,000 from federal funding, showing how federal law can limit and sway local decision making. This doesn’t mean we are doing something illegal, it just means our President hates us. Jim Ross kept repeating “the law is the law” and “I love diversity as much as I love the law”.

Only two out of seven people on the council voted against suspending this. Dr. Barbara Odom-Wesely, former mayor, spoke out against this act, stating, “If we suspend it, we are saying it is okay to discriminate. All men are created equal and discrimination is artificial.” and “To step back, is reversing hard fought generational battles on civil rights”. During public comments, Deejay Johannessan chimed in to say, “$161.02 is too much of a price to pay to protect people. Dallas and Fort Worth have not suspended their DEI. We are not special, why are we doing it?”. After the people spoke, Arlington mayor Jim Ross had nothing new to say, he just kept repeating his mantra of “the law is the law and I love the law”. Then the meeting ended, leaving a sour taste in my mouth.

Jim Ross attended and spoke at Arlington’s Pride Parade’s DRAG SHOW. Speaking out about his love for diversity and how everyone should be accepted and loved. Then proceeded to pull this act with no show of empathy or emotion. As a young non-binary gay asian who has been concerned about the direction red states have taken, I am angry and disappointed in Jim Ross. He should not be allowed to speak at next year’s pride unless he grovels on his knees.

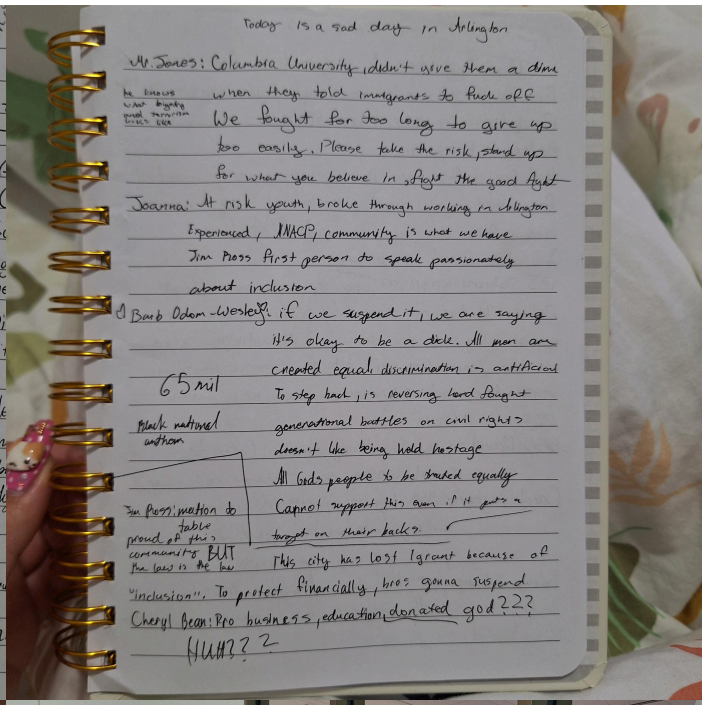
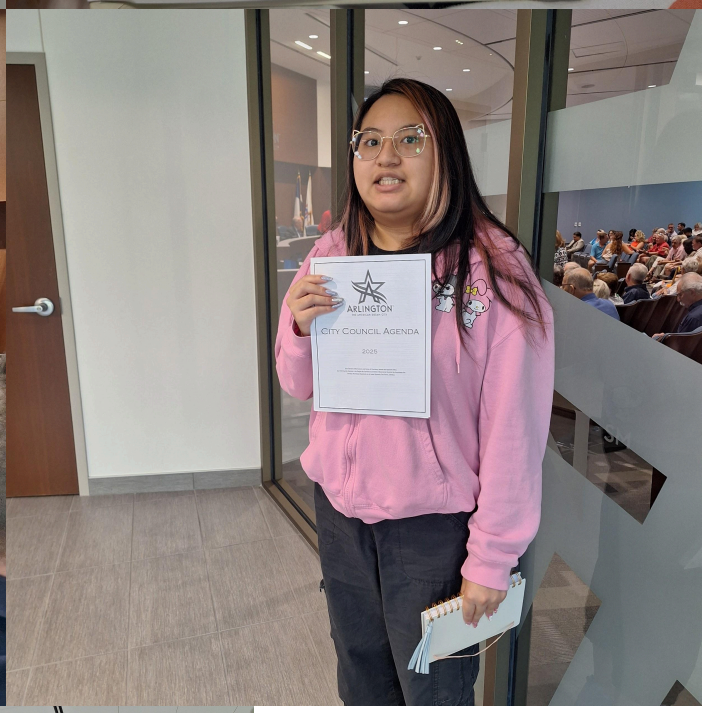
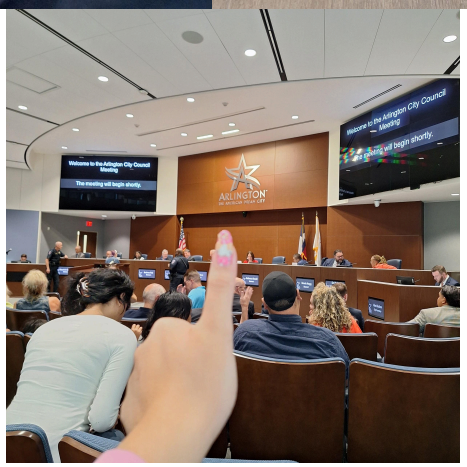
In addition, one public speaker wasted a minute of everyone’s time talking about herself, not the issue at hand. Cheryl Bean, who is running for State Representative yapped, “I am pro-business, pro-prosperity, and pro-education. I have donated the Ten Commandments to schools around AISD and out.” Then she left the room. Safe to say, I will not be voting for her. I will assume she was the only person for the suspension of the Anti-discrimination chapter.

The photos I have included are photos of me at City Hall and some notes I took while I was there. I refuse to take flattering photos.



yeetoob pump 4th most diverse U.S.

11 in Opposition to suspending Anti discrimination
Fort Worth suspended and didn't do anything to help
Cindy here for 40yrs: diversity, inclusion money=blackmail
Madger D Frank 44yrs:
Katherine Godby: Keep DEI = no money, also important
for white people: trapped in the role of being the
oppressor. People are being blackmailed
June Collins: Civil Disobedience
DJ Johanassen $161.02 too much price to pay to protect people
Dallas FW has not suspended DEI. We are not
special. Why are we doing it? Proactively solve
it like Unity Council. Attorney General says you
must have anti-discrimination, does not promot
DEI
David: We risk losing funding, Reinforce
social justice, reject Trumps attempt
Carol Playburn: Mech Engineer, experienced discrimination,
will only cause people to shut up, must
protect our city from Biggots removing
Timothy Schamp: from NY, chose Arlington, diversity,
friendly neighbors, this is giving up protection



Today is a sad day in Arlington
Mr. Jones: Columbia University didn't give them a dime
he knows what happens when they told immigrants to fuck off
We fought for too long to give up
too easily, Please take the risk, stand up
for what you believe in, fight the good fight
Joanna: At risk youth, broke through working in Arlington
Experienced, NAACP, community is what we have
Jim Ross first person to speak passionately
about inclusion
Barb Odom-Wesley: if we suspend it, we are saying
it's okay to be a dick. All men are
created equal, discrimination is antiAmerican
To step back, is reversing hard fought
generational battles on civil rights
doesn't like being held hostage
All Gods people to be treated equally
Cannot support this even if it gets a
target on their backs
This city has lost 1 grant because of
"inclusion". To protect financially, bros gonna suspend
Cheryl Bean: Pro business, education, donated god???
HUH??
65 mil
black national anthem
Jim Ross: motion to table
proud of this community BUT the law is the law